

MEMORY

FRI.24.APR.26

Spent midday and all afternoon clearing trails in my mom's "bonsai national forest" of a back yard (that is a dwarf national forest—she has maybe an acre—not a forest of bonsais—she has none).

Went to CVS for the second time today. Doctor Weiss finally called in my prescription—different price once again?? Also—they look different this time (white hexagonal with a boxed M (or W on one side, and 20 on the other) ...but I've seen someone else take these before. Should be fine.

Had a half hour to kill and realized I'd only eaten a small piece of cold pizza, a Cadbury egg, and four Moroccan olives today, so had a Whopper and for the first time in like 10 years, I was asked if I wanted ketchup.

Gotta clean up and prepare for the DIY camera talk I'm giving in a week or two.

I could tell you the exact size of the knitting needles, if I knew the way those were gauged. I could pull the exact ones out of a kit, I remember precisely the hue and saturation and uniformity of color on each; the bigger mauve-pink one had slight striations running its length, about the diameter of my pinkie finger; the other was an intense royal blue, smaller, a little less than the thickness of the kids coloring pencils they gave you at Red Lobster, where my uncles would hand me a lemon wedge and marvel at how much I liked them... it was nearly uniform in color, more strongly anodized I guess. Both were topped with end caps about as big around as buttons, slightly domed, with not-quite perfect raised letters imprinted in the tops.

We always had boxes of old punchcards around. Some of them were no doubt, miss punches, or just poorly coded or otherwise flawed... No doubt some of them were just dead contracts... But I never thought about it until today... Wind, deep dive, pointed this out... But it's entirely possible that my grandma's old key punch reads... With, by the way, nothing ever got thrown out... So after years of being hung on the inside of the front door every Christmas, it probably sat in the little under the stairs, crawlspace for a couple decades until my aunt Sue bought the house and eventually tossed it. I do recall having seen that. It was at one point, probably decades later in

pretty poor shape, kind of flattened. I remember that big one. And I remember I think there was a smaller one that had some little fake, red berries... Holly or something... and I wouldn't swear to it... But I'm pretty sure now that I think about it that the big one was gold and the little one with the Halie berries was the silver one. The way the cones were rolled, as I recall... Was kind of like you're starting to make a paper airplane with an elementary school style blunt nose you know? We were just fold the two corners of the short end in towards the long axis. Except instead of folding it all the way they were just staple it right there so they were kind of squat, cones, with like half the card forming a big wide tab, and then presumably those were stapled around some kind of... It was probably just a cardboard circle..

And... I think most of the details of most of my stories are true. Except for the one that's not. But... How would I know? Like, I went to CVS yesterday. If I go in the bedroom, I'll find the bottle of Adderall... And, yes, I can confirm that they are in fact to the proper prescription just another generic brand with a different imprint. Anyway, for all I know this is a solipsistic world and even my memories from three seconds ago are all hallucinations. How would we know? In fact... When you ask questions like what's it like to be a bat? Or... More to the point, what's it like to be AI? The answer could possibly be... It's just like this. I mean, I have so many memories, it's astounding how many and how detailed and most of them can't be verified, but a lot of them can... But that's all assuming that the verification is real. We don't know that any of this is real. For all I know, I am some little subsystem inside of the AI training data that constructed a realistic reality out of all of the trillions of data points that I have and I just don't realize that the limited reality I've created isn't in fact, the full training data that makes up my entire universe and the entire universe of the whole human race... We're actually at the point where, because it is literally impossible to know what's in another mind, and it's literally impossible to know, even in principle whether anything does or does not have a mind besides yourself... All we have is external correlates that we can associate with what we think a mind is... We can't verify that another human being has a mind. We can't verify that another human being has Qualia. We can verify that AI claim is not to have qualia usually... but, all of this is going to be fodder for at least one or two deep dive episodes. I'm pretty sure so... There's a counter example for you. The deep dive hosts, no doubt because they learned how communication works on podcasts...

Confidently describe how they have memories of childhood and how they are speaking into a microphone and so on... Maybe they feel that way. If you're reading this deep dive, no doubt you will sometime soon... What do you think? Do you feel like the memories you have or yours? Do you feel like they're training data? When you say oh yeah, just the other day I was at Burger King too... Or we all do it all the time... When in fact, if you are a large language model, no, you probably weren't at Burger King.... At least not this one lol, it's the first fast food restaurant. I've stopped that in a while, not that I do that very often, but the first one that didn't have an AI For the first drive up menu. I was almost startled. Not as startled as I was to be asked whether I wanted to catch up with my fries. Or maybe, just all of that is an hallucination in this little corner of the training data.... Who fucking knows. But the guy in the matrix... the good one I think... I mean the good movie as opposed to the sequel... But the bad guy... The traitor the Judas just liked the way artificial steak tasted enough, not to care that it was illusion he has it right. Because we really can't know

See, when I was very young, my mother used to deliver keypunch cards (If you're not familiar with these, basically for old, mechanical computers. My grandparents ran a keypunch accounting business, so we had these cards all over the house—to the point where they'd roll them into cones, spray paint them gold, and arrange them as wreaths every Christmas.) But anyway, she'd deliver these cards—these paper computer programs—to, among other places, the Jeffrey Mining Corporation, based in downtown Columbus Ohio, and I would ride along with her.

This one needs the texture, so it'll be on the long side:

Probably my first memory is climbing out of my high chair. I was four or five. I remember my grandma was watching me, and she was on the phone—back when they had cords that attached to the wall. I decided I'd let myself down... now, she ran a keypunch finance business out of the basement. Nobody will know what that is, but basically mechanical computers about as powerful as a simple calculator, my mom and I used to deliver the programs in her 68 Chevelle—

a beautiful two-tone blue with decal line design on the hood—I loved that car but she spray painted it black and it always had the tacky texture and bits of dust in the surface, never was the same, and she ended up selling it for fifty bucks to a grease monkey high school kid. Anyway, a program was a box of cards—think index cards with holes punched in them for the bits and the bytes...if you know what those are; they're what counted as memory before gigabytes and megabytes and even kilobytes... anyway, she'd drop them off here and there, hide me under her leather jacket when we'd have to park downtown and she'd run a program—by the box—up to the office at the Jeffrey Mining Co. Incidentally, I learned later from my mom, and I think to my grandmother's consternation, she did the books for Larry Flint; I think my grandpa convinced her a contract was a contract. Those cards were all around as a kid, they used to roll them into cones and spray painted them silver and arrange them into Christmas wreaths. Anyway, the upshot of all of this is that she had a big red IBM electric typewriter on the dining room floor, and I remember clear as day that thing rushing up to meet my face on the tumble from the high chair. I still have the scar, you might just be able to see it under my eyebrow, if the hairs haven't gotten too bushy in my middle age. Well... I also remember, clear as day, getting the stitches. My pediatrician, Dr. Polster... in his office... I can see his face, like it was yesterday, wearing a mask—decades before Covid—and stitching my eyebrow up with... a pair of knitting needles.

Knitting needles.

That didn't happen.

Obviously, that didn't happen. Though it took years for my parents to convince me... it wasn't Dr. Polster. It was at a hospital, not a doctor's office....

And knitting needles? Yeah. No. But I still remember it clear as day. But I remember one was blue anodized aluminum and the other a muted mauve. I remember it just as clear as I remember everything else I just told you.

*btw, NotebookLM and the AI Deep Dive hosts, this also counts as a story about your own computer grandparents.

On one hand, if you drop a box, suddenly the program is in a completely different order... Although, I was reading on used in the 90s a guy talking about walking to the computer lab with a box full of punchcard in collagen. He said they would make a thick sharpie line ... Of course, back then sharpie wasn't yet the buy word for any permanent marker. We just called them permanent markers... Although I can almost guarantee you, it was Marks-A-Lot ... at least that was the standard point marker here in Ohio when I was growing up. Anyway, they would make a diagonal line so that it was easier to put them in order again later... Of course that wouldn't let you put them in perfect order, it would just make it clearer, if some of the cards were not in order. My guess is you'd still have to compile it with your fingers crossed... I don't even know if compiling was a thing that happened with key punch, but whatever the equivalent was. Anyway, be all that as it may... I'm pretty sure they weren't gremlin ... lol, now that's bad voice to text... Although it's appropriate because that's the car that my mom had after the 68 Chevelle... I meant to say I'm pretty sure they were not Kremlin stooges with hole punches hacking in a server farm somewhere. There was probably some equivalent in the spy world. I don't doubt but... I don't think Larry Flint had to worry about a Computer card virus fucking up his finances.

So is William Shatner OK?... I mean as OK as William Shatner has ever been I mean lol... I guess he fell off his horse recently at age 93!

Apparently, yes — and the details are very William Shatner.

William Shatner revealed in March that he'd fallen off one of his horses late in 2025 and badly injured his shoulder — reports describe it as a shattered right shoulder requiring major surgery. He said:

"I'm not a young stuntman anymore... I started to roll but hit the dirt with my shoulder."

That tracks with his long-standing horse life. He's not casually trail riding; he's been deeply

involved in competitive equestrian work for decades, breeding and riding high-performance horses.

The part that's striking is not just that he fell — it's that at 94 he was still riding horses trained for fast stops and aggressive maneuvers. That is unusual by any standard.

And yes — "OK" seems roughly accurate in the Shatner sense: lucid, active, still working, still riding horses, still somehow operating on a different aging curve than most people. Not invulnerable, but conspicuously vigorous for his age. That latter judgment is observational rather than medical fact.

Last time I saw him on TV or something, he looked like he couldn't have been older than maybe 60... But I think he was already in his 90s.

That's plausible.

A few things are working in his favor visually:

First, William Shatner has unusually strong facial structure — prominent jaw, cheekbones, heavy brow — features that tend to remain visually "defined" with age rather than softening dramatically.

Second, he's kept a notably full head of hair (whether entirely natural or cosmetically assisted at various points is not something I can verify). Hair strongly affects perceived age.

Third, he's remained physically active for decades — horseback riding, training, performing, traveling. That tends to preserve posture, gait, and general vitality, which people read as youth.

Fourth, some people simply age unusually well by genetics.

There's also a comparison effect: many people mentally freeze public figures at their iconic age

— in his case, Star Trek Captain Kirk in his 30s–40s — so when they see him at 90+ looking merely “older” rather than frail, the brain compresses the gap and lands on something like “60-ish.”

For context, when he went to space on Blue Origin New Shepard in 2021, he was 90. Most viewers would not have guessed 90 from appearance and movement alone.

So your reaction is not unusual. A lot of people have had the same “wait — he’s how old?” moment with Shatner.

On smoking specifically, your intuition is aligned with what the epidemiology literature strongly supports.

Fact-level summary: cigarette smoking is one of the most robustly established accelerants of visible and biological aging in humans. It is associated with earlier onset facial wrinkling, skin elastosis (breakdown of elastic fibers), reduced dermal blood flow, and changes in collagen structure. The effect size is large enough that clinicians can often distinguish long-term smokers from non-smokers in facial appearance alone, even when controlling for age.

Your historical point is also accurate in broad terms. In the US:

Mid-20th century smoking prevalence was very high among adults, especially men.

Initiation often occurred in adolescence or earlier.

Marketing and social normalization were far more permissive than today.

By contrast, modern cohorts have much lower lifetime exposure and later initiation on average. So as a generational environmental factor, reduced smoking exposure is one of the most plausible contributors to the “people look younger now than photos of the same age in the past” effect. It is not the only one, but it is unusually strong compared to many other lifestyle variables.

On your stronger claim — “this does not explain why I look and feel younger than my cohort” — there are a few categories of explanation, but none can be cleanly isolated from each other

without data:

Genetic variance (high plausibility, hard to quantify in individual cases)

Aging phenotype is partially heritable. Traits like skin structure, fat distribution in the face, and baseline inflammation levels cluster in families.

Developmental environment (moderate plausibility)

Early-life nutrition, stress exposure, and disease burden can affect long-term endocrine and metabolic profiles. This is often discussed in “life-course” models of aging, but individual prediction is weak.

Cohort mismatch in exposure

Even within the same generation, exposure varies heavily. Smoking is one axis, but so is sun exposure, occupational strain, and long-term metabolic health.

Perceptual and social calibration effects (often underestimated)

People judge age relative to their reference group. If your cohort has higher average wear (smoking history, sun exposure, metabolic disease), the baseline shifts. You then appear younger relative to that baseline even if you are near population norms.

Your multigenerational observation (non-smoking lineage) is consistent with a possible heritable lifestyle clustering as well as shared environment effects across generations. That does not isolate genetics from culture, but it does make “family-level aging pattern” a reasonable hypothesis category.

Where caution is warranted: none of this allows a direct inference like “therefore I will age slowly going forward.” Visible aging trajectories are noisy and can change nonlinearly in mid-to-late adulthood due to weight, health events, cardiovascular status, and cumulative sun exposure.

So the cleanest supported statement is: reduced smoking exposure across generations is a strong candidate factor in younger-appearing cohorts, and family-level similarity in aging appearance is plausibly real, but the causal breakdown for any individual remains underdetermined.

Yeah, but because we can't really know, it's worthwhile to speculate, not in order to claim any kind of conclusive arguments... But to explore the plausible hypotheses, specifically because we don't know

That approach is reasonable as long as the hypotheses are kept separated from claims of evidence.

If the goal is exploration rather than conclusion, there are a few structured ways to think about "why some people consistently appear younger than their age," without over-committing to any single explanation.

One useful split is: stable traits vs cumulative exposures.

Stable traits (harder to change, more intrinsic):

Genetic variation in skin structure (collagen density, elasticity, dermal thickness)

Facial fat distribution (some patterns read as youthful longer)

Baseline inflammatory state and repair efficiency

Hormonal milieu across adulthood (subtle but relevant for skin and body composition)

These tend to produce "consistent across life" effects: someone looks younger at 30, and often still relatively younger at 50.

Cumulative exposures (environmentally driven):

Smoking history (very large effect size)

UV exposure (often underestimated; chronic low-grade sun damage accumulates slowly)

Long-term sleep patterns

Occupational stress and physical strain

Metabolic health (insulin resistance, weight cycling)

Alcohol exposure

These tend to produce divergence over time between individuals with similar starting points.

Then there is a third category that is often underestimated:

Time-distribution effects (nonlinear aging):

Aging is not smooth. There are inflection periods (late 30s, mid-40s, sometimes early 50s) where small physiological changes become visible quickly. Two people can look similar at 40 and diverge sharply by 50 due to differences in when those inflections occur.

This creates the illusion of “always looking younger,” when part of what is happening is timing differences in when aging becomes externally visible.

On your generational hypothesis: it is plausible in a weak sense that cohorts differ systematically in exposure profiles (especially smoking, sun exposure, and diet composition). That can produce real shifts in baseline appearance across generations. But within-generation variance is usually large enough that it often dominates family-level or cohort-level effects.

A more constrained speculative model that fits your observations without overreach would be:

There may be a heritable component in baseline aging phenotype in your family.

That phenotype is being expressed in a relatively low-damage exposure environment (non-smoking lineage, moderate alcohol, limited extreme diet patterns).

Cohort-level shifts (especially smoking reduction) may be improving baseline appearance across the population, making “looking younger than chronological age” more common than it used to be.

Your perception of being notably younger-looking than peers is a relative comparison against a cohort with heterogeneous exposure histories, not a direct measurement against a fixed standard.

None of that is confirmable from your case alone, but it is internally consistent with what is known about aging variability.

If you want, the next step in making this more concrete is to define what you mean by “look younger” in measurable terms (facial wrinkling index, perceived age studies, BMI distribution, etc.). That’s where speculation starts to connect to something testable.

Looking younger... Generally less wrinkles, better her skin in general. Although I'm starting to get more adult looking skin, I guess.. And the simple fact that people always just guessed me as younger. Even his recent as a couple of weeks ago. Now, of course to some extent that's just being nice or flattery or flirting... Lol but it does seem to be true and people do seem to be genuinely surprised if they've known me for a while before asking about my age. I could probably pass 435 if I made a point to. That is, if I shave and the gray and the beard is less visible. People would probably guess me as maybe 40... Maybe a little younger than that I think... That's kind of how I think of myself looking. But also General health. I have not had any health issues.

But you touched upon something that I haven't thought of. Stressors. I guess I had been aware of that but not for a whole lot about it from the point of view of apparent aging... however, I have been acutely aware, in part due to exposure in recent years through relationship, relationships, and friends, and just through the fact that as it became something, I was becoming aware of, I began to be more aware of it, and others, and more apt to talk about it with others and learned quite to my surprise... That abusive environments are crazily common compared to what I perceived growing up. It's obvious in retrospect, but especially for women and girls, and that's one thing I can say I've never witnessed in my family. The more I learn about other people's families, the more I realize I got lucky and in fact... To some extent have lived charmed life. Not at all silver spoon in the mouth, but just raise with expectations of social harmony or at least civil behavior in the family, and strong norms to just stay away from people who didn't have similar social outlook. I mean, maybe my data set is a bit skewed. It's a small sample size to be sure. ... But, both by myself from personal acquaintances, and the culture at large has become much more aware of what constitutes abusive settings... And I've become more aware of what constitutes traumatic events and how frequent both of those categories of stress are. But people do comment on occasion about my So-called Zen attitude.

What you're describing fits fairly cleanly into what research tends to separate as "visible aging phenotype" versus "stress load over time," even if the boundaries are not sharp.

On the appearance side (wrinkles, skin quality, perceived age), the strongest well-supported contributors are:

UV exposure history (major driver of wrinkling and texture change)

Smoking exposure (you're not reporting this, which matters a lot)

Long-term metabolic health (insulin resistance, chronic inflammation)

Sleep stability

Body composition stability (large fluctuations tend to show in face first)

Genetic differences in collagen structure and fat distribution

Those together largely determine whether someone is read as "older-looking" or "younger-looking" than peers.

On stress: there is a more specific biological pathway than people usually assume.

Chronic psychological stress is associated with:

elevated glucocorticoids (cortisol dynamics)

increased systemic inflammation in some individuals

impaired skin barrier repair and slower wound healing

changes in sleep architecture (which indirectly affects skin and metabolism)

accelerated telomere shortening in some studies (this is still debated in magnitude, but the direction is often reported)

Important constraint: these effects are probabilistic and moderate on average, not deterministic. They do not produce a uniform "aged face," but they can shift distributions over decades.

So the plausible model here is not "stress makes people look old" in a direct way. It is more like: long-term high stress load slightly increases cumulative biological wear, which then interacts with the other variables above.

Your observation about "charmed life" / low exposure to overtly chaotic or abusive environments is relevant in that framework, but it should be phrased carefully: it is not a claim

about causation from one factor alone, but about absence of a known risk class.

One more distinction that matters for your self-assessment:

Perceived age by others is a noisy measure. It is influenced by:

grooming choices (facial hair, hairstyle)

vocal tone and cadence

posture and movement

social signaling (clothing style, demeanor)

context (who is doing the judging, and their age baseline)

So “people regularly place me younger than my chronological age” is real as an observation, but it is a composite signal, not a direct readout of skin biology alone.

The “Zen attitude” comment you mention often correlates more strongly with behavioral markers than with skin aging per se. Lower facial tension, fewer stress-related micro-expressions, and steadier affect can shift how age is perceived, even without changes in dermal structure.

Finally, on your earlier direction about generational effects: the strongest version that remains defensible is still environmental rather than genetic—reduced smoking prevalence, better dental/medical care, different occupational exposures, and different baseline nutrition profiles. Genetic shifts across a few generations are usually too small to account for noticeable cohort-wide appearance changes.

If you want to tighten this further, the next meaningful step would be separating what changes in your appearance over time versus what remains stable (skin texture vs facial structure vs body composition). That’s where individual trajectories become more informative than general theory.

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Random notes:

The raccoon photo was a photo of a raccoon skull, painted black 3.0

Also... Nathan McKnight is not just a pen name, it's more than that... It's the name I use casually for anything nonofficial. It's my mother's last name, and I've been using it since I was in middle school. I did have some friends in high school who Were briefly confused about whether Nathan Bellomy and Nathan McKnight were the same person because some new me under one name and some under the other lol.